would presumably secure a political insurance against the erosion of its sovereign independence, which is otherwise impossible to retain through proximity to one or the other of the major powers.[4]

However, non-alignment as a concept has often created confusion as well as earned criticisms from different quarters. It is wrongly perceived to be somewhat similar to neutrality which enjoys legal recognition for several centuries as a position of non-belligerency defined by some specific treaty obligations and rights. Nehru attempted to dispel the confusion between the two concepts by observing that “neutrality as a policy had little meaning except in time of war”, whereas India preferred “to keep away from the power politics of groups aligned against one another which had led in the past to two world wars, and which might again lead to disasters on an even vaster scale”.[5]

In practice, non-alignment has come to mean more than not joining the military alliances or maintaining neutrality during cold or hot war. Its main aim has been to reduce the risks of conflict between the hostile blocs by keeping out of them and to broaden the area of peace in the world. But like neutrality, which has sometimes destroyed neutral nations and most of the time stood violated once war broke out, non-alignment also ran the risk of a similar kind of fate. Therefore, the non-aligned states embarked on the policy of “peace, commerce and honest friendship with all nations and entangling alliances with none”.

Nevertheless, the negative connotation in non-alignment has been a constant source of irritation to those who believed in the rightness of formation of military blocs for preserving security. John Foster Dulles once declared non-alignment as “immoral”, and Stalin too doubted its motive. Stalin doubted India as “a running dog of British imperialism” and ironically Dulles thought that Soviet Communism exercised a strong influence in India.

Nehru at the first NAM Summit at Belgrade in 1961 said “We call ourselves non-aligned countries. The word ‘Non-Aligned’ may be differently interpreted, but basically it was coined and used with the meaning of being Non-Aligned with the great power blocs of the world…Non-aligned has a negative meaning. But if we give it a